

TEXTILES
Lithuania has a strong textile industry, with clothes, bed linen, curtains, and towels made for export. Estonia and Latvia are also famous for their linen products, many beautifully hand-crafted.



FARMING
The fertile soils and flat landscapes make this region good for farming. The Baltic States, particularly Latvia (left), have large dairy farms. Belarus is a major producer of flax, which is used to make linen and other products. Potatoes (used to make vodka), sugar beet, and other root crops are also grown here.



LITHUANIAN COSTUME
In some Lithuanian villages people wear traditional folk costumes for festive occasions. Women's clothing is generally colorful (left) and might include a white linen shirt, a skirt, and an apron. The decoration and style of the costume shows which region of Lithuania the wearer comes from.

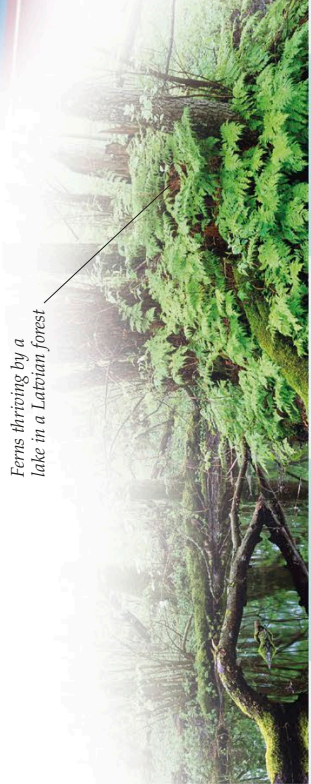


GYMNASTICS
The former Soviet Union worked its young athletes and gymnasts extremely hard in order to win Olympic medals and thus national glory. Many of the most famous gymnasts of the era came from Belarus, notably Olga Korbut and Svetlana Boginskaya (right), who won three gold, one silver, and one bronze Olympic medals.



Ferns thriving by a lake in a Latvian forest

FORESTS AND LAKES
All four countries are low-lying with many moors, bogs, unspoiled lakes, and fir and pine forests. Forestry is an important industry, especially in Estonia and Latvia, providing wood pulp for paper making, and timber for furniture and houses.



MINSK
The capital of Belarus, Minsk, was destroyed during World War II and then rebuilt in a starkly modern style. Minsk is the country's economic center. Cars, trucks and tractors, electrical household goods, and equipment are all produced here. Farm produce (above) is also sold in the markets.

